

# The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Bloomberg via Getty Images

**America** shot down four **Iranian** drones that “posed an immediate threat to regional maritime traffic”, its forces said. US Central Command also struck Iranian radar sites near the Strait of Hormuz. Iran fired missiles at American bases in Kuwait and Bahrain in return, although most were intercepted, and attacked four tankers attempting to cross Hormuz. Pakistan’s interior minister is reportedly en route to Tehran to help revive negotiations to [end the war](#).

The **Nasdaq** index of technology companies suffered its biggest daily drop in more than a year, falling more than 4% amid a wider sell-off. The decline, driven by weakness in artificial-intelligence stocks and a [better-than-expected jobs report](#), abruptly ended the market’s record-breaking run. American employers added 172,000 jobs in May, stoking fears that further inflation will force the Federal Reserve to raise interest rates this year.

**SpaceX** agreed to lease computing capacity to **Google** in a three-year deal worth \$30bn. The rocketry firm is banking on demand for AI infrastructure to boost revenues ahead of its [blockbuster IPO](#) next week, in which the firm is seeking a valuation of \$1.8trn. Last month it announced a similar agreement with Anthropic, an AI firm.

At the 82nd anniversary of the **D-Day landings** in Normandy, France, **Pete Hegseth** warned of Europe's beaches being "stormed by different, dangerous ideologies" in the form of "boats and men". America's war secretary also said that Europe must take responsibility for its own defence. The Trump administration has been critical of what it sees as Europe's lax immigration policy and [meagre defence spending](#).

**Vladimir Putin** rejected **Volodymyr Zelensky's** proposal for face-to-face talks, saying he sees "no point" in them. Ukraine's president had suggested meeting in a third country to discuss "the front line today" as Ukraine has taken the [initiative](#) on the battlefield. Meanwhile, the two countries have been swapping heavy aerial strikes. On Friday a Russian drone killed four people near Kyiv, Ukraine's capital.

**Iran's footballers** were given visas to enter America ahead of the World Cup, according to the White House. On Thursday an Iranian official had claimed that the squad had yet to receive its paperwork for the tournament, which begins on June 11th. Iran is due to play three games in America but has moved its base from Arizona to Tijuana in Mexico, a co-host.

Five of the seven astronauts aboard the **International Space Station** were evacuated onto a docked SpaceX vessel after an air leak in Russia's Zvezda module worsened. [NASA](#) objected to Russia's repair method, which involved using a saw to access the crack. The crew were allowed to return once the cosmonauts attempting to fix the leak stopped. Russia said the crew faced no immediate threat.

**Word of the week:** *Paz Total*, Gustavo Petro's failed policy to engage with all of Colombia's rebel groups at once. The outgoing leftist president's successor may [choose to break with it](#).



Photograph: Getty Images/The Economist

## **Putin may soon face a choice**

A somewhat mocking open letter from Volodymyr Zelensky to Vladimir Putin this week reflects Ukraine's growing confidence that the military tables are turning in its favour. Mr Zelensky's message was that his Russian counterpart could not afford the rising human and economic cost of the war. Russia's economy is taking a hit from Ukrainian drone strikes on energy infrastructure. Adding insult to injury, Ukraine struck an oil depot near where delegates were arriving for Mr Putin's showpiece economic forum in St Petersburg on Wednesday.

Mr Zelensky proposed a face-to-face meeting to hammer out a ceasefire agreement based on the current front lines. There is little sign of that happening for now. But if Russia's summer offensive continues to make scant progress, Mr Putin may face an uncomfortable dilemma after parliamentary elections in September: to either push for a risky mobilisation of conscripts, or put the best face possible on a ceasefire.



Photograph: Reuters

## India's Gen-Z “cockroaches”

Last month Surya Kant, India's chief justice, [lamented](#) that there were “youngsters like cockroaches, they don't get any employment, they don't have any place in the (legal) profession”. Within a day, an Indian student in Boston had created the Cockroach Janta Party, a satirical outfit for the “lazy and unemployed”. Mr Kant later walked back his remarks, but that did little to stop the CJP's viral breakout. It has amassed over 22m followers on Instagram, more than twice as many as the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party.

The joke has transformed into a Gen-Z movement, feeding on young Indians' anger over unemployment and a scandal involving high-school exam leaks and marking irregularities. On Saturday the CJP's founder, Abhijeet Dipke, is due to arrive in Delhi, where he has called a protest demanding the resignation of the education minister. Authorities have already blocked CJP's X account in India. They may well clamp down on the streets, too. Roaches, however, are hard to stamp out.



Photograph: Getty Images

## Leo's Spanish sojourn

Pope Leo arrived in Spain on Saturday. His visit will require stamina—it is nearly a week long—as well as political deftness. In Madrid on Monday, he will become the first pontiff to address a Spanish parliament. This one is acrimoniously polarised. In May, Leo had an apparently friendly meeting with the [Socialist prime minister](#), Pedro Sánchez. Conservatives will be looking for any further sign that he is, as right-wing critics aver, a “[woke pope](#)”.

In Catalonia, Leo will celebrate mass in Antoni Gaudí's extraordinary (and still unfinished) basilica, the Sagrada Família. He will also visit the monastery of Montserrat, a bastion of Catalan nationalism. And on the final leg, in the Canary Islands, he risks further controversy at meetings with migrants and representatives of organisations that support them, amid growing antipathy towards migrants across Europe that is fuelling the rise of far-right groups. Watch also for an encounter with survivors of clerical sex abuse; it would be his first such since being elected.



Photograph: Ellis O'Brien/Prime Video

## Down on the farm with Jeremy Clarkson

When [Jeremy Clarkson](#) left the BBC motoring show “Top Gear” under a cloud in 2015, it was unforeseeable that Britain’s most famous petrolhead might become its most celebrated advocate for agriculture. Yet that has been the effect of his reality series “Clarkson’s Farm”, which returned this week for a fifth season as Amazon Prime’s most popular show in Britain, and a global hit.

Perhaps nobody has done more to increase public understanding of modern farming and its difficulties than Mr Clarkson. He has succeeded because of, not despite, his unsuitability for the role; viewers delight in his expletive-laden clashes with, to name a few: Britain’s planning system, NIMBY culture, health-and-safety rules and ecowarriors. Much of Mr Clarkson’s schtick rests on his performative ineptitude. But in recent years his sprawling Oxfordshire farm has reportedly doubled in value to £13m. Expect him to keep milking it.



Photograph: Getty Images

## **Weekend profile: Graham Platner, the scandal-ridden oysterman hoping to catch Maine**

Graham Platner's campaign video shows him cruising through Maine's waterways on a motorboat clad in a tattered blue T-shirt and sun-reflecting shades. The burly, bearded 41-year-old describes his life over a hard-rock backing track: "A decade of military service going overseas, farming oysters to feed my community, diving to lend a hand to other fishermen, trying to start a family". Other shots show him chopping wood, swinging kettlebells and strolling along a beach with his wife. "I did four infantry tours [...] I'm not afraid to name an enemy," he says in a gravelly baritone. "And the enemy is the oligarchy. It's the billionaires who pay for it, the politicians who sell us out."

Mr Platner's portrayal as a straight-talking, hardscrabble outsider has helped him to hook Democrats: he is expected to win Maine's Senate primary on June 9th. (The campaign video racked up 2.5m views in under 24 hours on X, a social-media platform; one enraptured Twitch user commented that he "looks like a progressive mind in a MAGA body".) If victorious, he will face Susan Collins, a moderate Republican in her fifth term who is 32 years his senior. The race matters far beyond the state: Maine is one of four seats Democrats are likely to need if they are to regain control of the Senate in November.

Until recently, Mr Platner looked sure to win the nomination—so much so that his main challenger, Janet Mills, suspended her campaign in April. But now the oysterman faces a darkening storm. He previously courted controversy for a tattoo associated with Nazism and bigoted social-media posts in his past. But in the past week he has made headlines again. First, for explicit messages apparently sent to multiple women in 2023, when he was married. Then, the *New York Times* detailed allegations made by his former romantic partners of “unsettling” behaviour. One woman accused him of physical intimidation. Mr Platner denied those accusations.

So far Mr Platner’s life story has helped him weather the scandal. After his parents divorced, his mother moved the family to Sullivan, a small town in eastern Maine. A college dropout, he became a marine infantryman in 2003, serving four tours in Iran and Afghanistan. He got the tattoo, of a skull and crossbones, while on a break with comrades; he claims he did not know it was associated with Nazism and has inked it over. He said he posted extreme statements while suffering from alienation and depression brought on by combat, and that returning to Sullivan to work on the water to “feel connected again”.

Allegations of infidelity may be harder to dismiss. Sensing an opening, Ms Mills posted from her campaign’s X account after the texting allegations appeared, and reminded reporters that she had never officially dropped out—meaning her name would still appear on the ballot. But rather than repel voters, his flaws may leave struggling Americans to conclude that he is one of their own.

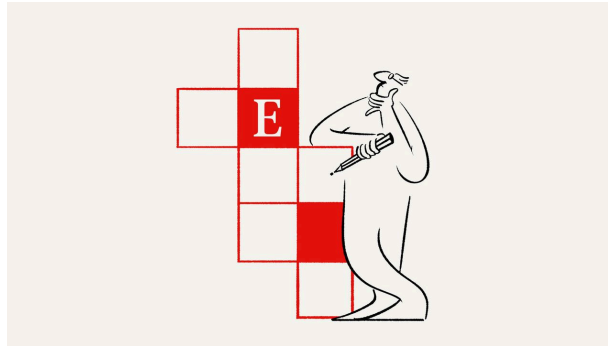


Illustration: The Economist

## Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

### Cryptic clues

*1 across* - Arrange two at a capital on the 45th parallel (6)

*2 across* - Reptile came in on the radio (6)

*3 across* - Clergy excommunicated chlorine for neon, returning vigour (6)

*1 down* - Corrupted nice incomes to know all (11)

### Straight clues

*1 across* - North American city initially named “Bytown” (6)

*2 across* - With “Islands”: A financial haven (6)

*3 across* - Power x Time (6)

*1 down* - A trait of divine beings in most religions (11)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

## The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

**Kevin Osinski**, Medina, Washington, America

**Sandra Lindstrom**, North Saanich, British Columbia, Canada

**Jaeho Lee**, Seoul, South Korea

They gave the correct answers of the Northwest passage, windows, birds, steps and Rebecca. The theme is films directed by Alfred Hitchcock: "North by Northwest", "Rear Window", "The Birds", "The 39 Steps" and "Rebecca"

The questions were:

**Monday:** The British ships *HMS Erebus* and *HMS Terror* were lost in 1845 in the attempt to navigate which waterway?

**Tuesday:** Casement, sash and bay are types of which architectural feature?

**Wednesday:** Which highly-common animal group is believed to have descended from dinosaurs?

**Thursday:** The recovery programme at Alcoholics Anonymous consists of 12 what?

**Friday:** Who in the Bible was Isaac's wife (and mother of Jacob and Esau)?

*Who looks outside dreams; who  
looks inside awakes.*

---

***Carl Jung***